



2026-2027 / Formation Généraliste / Cycle Master / Majeures 5A / Montpellier / Data Engineering / MMMDE5IN32-26 / Resources / Never run /init

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[↑](#) [Retour à « Resources »](#)

Never Run **/init**

<https://www.aihero.dev/never-run-claude-init>

/init is the first command most people run in a new repo. It offers to read your codebase and write a **CLAUDE.md** (or **AGENTS.md**) describing it. It feels like setup — like the responsible thing to do before you start. Matt Pocock's advice is blunter than "be careful with it": don't run it, and delete the file if you already have one.

The reason isn't that the generated file is inaccurate. On the day it's written it's usually correct. The reason is *where* that file lives in the request.

The file is fixed, and everything else is not

Your agent's **context window** has two kinds of occupants. The **system prompt** — tool schemas, harness instructions, your **CLAUDE.md** — is hardwired the moment the **session** starts and re-sent on every **turn**. Everything else — reading files, searching, editing, running tests — is flexible, and it's where the actual work happens.

A generated **CLAUDE.md** takes space from the second category and gives it to the first. Permanently, for every session, whether or not the session has anything to do with what the file describes.

Instruction budget

The cost isn't only **tokens**. Every sentence in **CLAUDE.md** is an instruction the model is holding while it works, and models can only track so many at once — realistically 300–400, perhaps 500 on the largest ones. Spend a hundred of those on the shape of your monorepo before the task is even stated and you've narrowed what's left for the task.

The article cites research finding that unnecessary context files make tasks *harder*, not easier (arxiv.org/abs/2602.11988) — the instructions don't sit inertly, they compete.

The globality problem

CLAUDE.md loads for every session. Not the frontend ones. All of them.

So the React conventions you documented are also loaded when you're writing a migration, fixing CI, or editing a README. They're irrelevant there, but you pay for them anyway, and the model still has to decide they don't apply. Something that's useful a third of the time is a cost the other two thirds — and it's the same file either way.

What **/init** actually writes

Go through a generated file section by section and each part fails for its own reason:

- **Command listings** (**pnpm build**, **pnpm test**) — a duplicate of **package.json**, which the agent can read in one tool call when it needs to.
- **Architecture descriptions** — framework names and settings that are already legible from the config files and the imports.
- **File and service references** — correct today, wrong after the next refactor. This is the worst category, because a stale pointer doesn't just waste space, it actively sends the agent to the wrong place.
- **Implementation patterns** — relevant to a subset of sessions, and discoverable from the code that already follows them.

Every line is either rediscoverable in seconds or destined to rot.

The bar

Something belongs in **CLAUDE.md** only if it clears both tests:

1. **Undiscoverable** — the agent cannot work it out from the codebase.
2. **Globally relevant** — it's true in every session, whatever the task.

Pocock's example of a line that passes: *"you are on WSL on Windows."* Six words. Nothing in the repo reveals it, and it changes how the agent behaves in every single session. Almost nothing **/init** generates clears the same bar.

What to do instead

Trust the explore step. Modern agents already read files and search the codebase before acting. That loads exactly what this task needs, and it reflects the code as it is right now rather than as it was when the doc was written. Just-in-time beats just-in-case — and it can't go stale.

Steer with skills. Genuine preferences — reducers over **useState**, how you want tests structured — belong in skills. A skill is discoverable: the agent pulls it in when the work calls for it, and pays nothing for it when it doesn't. That's the same guidance without the global tax.

Keep **CLAUDE.md nearly empty.** Not empty as a rule of thumb — empty as a default, with lines added only when they clear the bar above.

The bottom line

 Never run init... You'll either burn tokens keeping it up to date, or you'll delete it. Just skip to deleting it.

The generated file has exactly two futures, and both of them cost you. One costs you maintenance forever; the other costs you the time between now and when you finally give up on it.